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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER V c. 1904-1907 A GIRL'S FIRST MARRIAGE () • Marriage of Almsgiving ()

Before the marriage had 'taken' the bridegroom's younger brother would come and tease the bride, he would look at her spinning and say 'It's no good!' he would break the thread and she would get up and hit him and chase him away. He is her joking relation. For three months the bride does no housework, except that she will help a little in grinding the grain. This allows her to become accustomed to her new home.

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When women-slaves got married, their master was their *wali*. (¹⁰⁶) If he freed one of his woman-slaves, her own parents could act as her *wali*, otherwise it was her master.

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Marriage of Almsgiving (¹⁰⁷)

There is another kind of marriage where the bridegroom's kin pay nothing for the bride; this is called a marriage of alms. If a man wishes to give another a gift, whether it is a *malam* or just someone he likes, then he will collect cloth, guineacorn, millet, rice, and the other marriage gifts, and put them together. He says nothing to the man who is to be bridegroom. He tells his daughter what he wants to do; if she refuses to be married to the man her father has

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chosen, they try to persuade her, but if she keeps on refusing, they drop the matter—she would not settle down. If she agrees, then one morning the marriage ceremony is held, and she is married to a representative of the Prophet. Late that night her mother's younger brother and her father's or her mother's mother  100 take her to the compound of the *malam* who is to receive her. They call out 'Peace be upon you!' The door is opened, 'Upon you be peace!' 'Here is alms, we have brought alms to so-and-so'. They take the bride into the compound. Next morning the *malam* who has received this gift collects twenty thousand cowries—nowadays he would take about £1—he assembles about ten *malams* and they take the money and some cloth and go to the entrance-hut of the bride's father. They give him the money as the gift we always give to one who brings presents, and the cloth is for the bride. My younger 'sister' Barmo was married like that, and my elder 'sister' Bagura, they were married in Zarewa. Barmo was given to Yusufu, Bagura was given to Balarabe. There was Kande, she was given to Dalhatu. Some of the girls refuse to be given as alms, then they will be married to the man they prefer.

Wali—see notes 13 and 15, also Ch. V, and Ruxton op. cit., p. 90 and footnote.

Marriage of alms— *auren sadaka*, cf. pp. 129, 153 *et al.*

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